Manager Tell-All Interview

Park: _____ **Manager:** _____ **Date:** _____

Part D: Prove the numbers.

Takes in: your AS-03 notes and the rent roll.

Hands to: AS-14 (flag the surprises), AS-18 (plan the handoff).

The manager has run this park longer than you have owned anything. They know where the bodies are buried, which tenants pay, and what breaks every winter. This interview gets it out of them, on paper, before the seller's story hardens into your problem. Get the seller's written permission first. Promise the manager nothing about their job.

1. The fair housing box: read before you ask anything

You are asking about conduct and money, never about who people are. Protected characteristics are never your business and never go in your notes.

- ☐ Ask about payment history, lease violations, and police calls to the park. Write down conduct only.
- ☐ If the manager starts describing tenants by who they are instead of what they did, stop them and redirect to conduct.
- ☐ Never ask the manager to warn you about tenants by identity. Ask: "Any lots with repeated late payments or lease violations?"

2. The manager as an asset: size up the person, not just the facts

- ☐ Tenure: how long have they managed this park? Who did they work for before?
- ☐ Hours and pay: what are the real hours and the real pay? Is any of it off the books?
- ☐ Housing benefit: do they live on site? Is there a written agreement for the unit?
- ☐ Keys and passwords: every key, gate code, and password they hold. You collect all of them at closing.
- ☐ Vendor relationships: who do they call for septic, electric, trash, propane? How long have those vendors served the park?
- ☐ What would they change first if the park were theirs?

3. The interview: ask, then shut up

Collections

1. "Walk me through rent collection, start to finish. Who pays how, and when?"
2. "Who is behind right now, and by how much? What is the plan for each one?"
3. "What deposits are you holding, and where is that money?"

Tenants (conduct only, see the box above)

4. "Which lots have repeated late payments or lease violations?"
5. "How many police calls to the park in the last 12 months, and for what?"
6. "Any evictions or notices in progress right now?"

Maintenance backlog

7. "What is the biggest deferred repair on the park right now?"
8. "What breaks every single year?"
9. "If you had $10,000 for repairs tomorrow, what would you fix first?"

Front continues on page 2: infrastructure questions, the 2 a.m. question, tacit knowledge, the Verify One rule, vendor interviews, and the retain / transition / replace decision.

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Infrastructure trouble spots

10. "Where are the water and sewer trouble spots? Show me on the lot map."
11. "When the water main breaks at 2 a.m., who do you call, in what order?"
12. "What does everyone here know that is not written down anywhere?"
13. "If you left tomorrow, what breaks first?"

Three evasive-answer signals

- "You should ask the owner" on basic operations questions. The manager runs the park; not knowing is itself an answer.
- Numbers that change between the first telling and the second. Write down both versions.
- Rushing past a specific lot or system. Slow down there. That is where the interview actually starts.

4. The Verify One rule

Every material claim the manager makes gets checked against a document within 72 hours. Occupancy against the rent roll and bank deposits. Pay and hours against the P and L. Vendor claims against the vendor interview below. A claim with no document behind it is worth $0 until it has one.

5. The second interview: the vendors

Interview the septic pumper, the electrician, the trash hauler, and the propane supplier. Vendors know what the park costs and how it fails. Ask each one: what do you service here, what is about to fail, and what would you fix first? That is pure field knowledge no competitor can copy from a PDF.

6. The decision: retain, transition, or replace

- ☐ Retain: the manager is the operation. Written role, written pay, 90-day goals.
- ☐ Transition: keep them 60 to 90 days to train the replacement, then a clean handoff.
- ☐ Replace: the manager is the problem. Name the replacement before closing.

Decision (circle one): retain / transition / replace: ____ If transition or replace, the replacement is: _____

Manager retention plan added as a first-30-days line item (Y/N): _____

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Worked example: Maple Bend Estates (fictional)

Fictional park, fictional manager, real arithmetic. Seeds: 48 lots, ask $1,650,000, bank deposits $189,000, seller expenses $71,000. The interview answers below are invented to show the method; the math is checked.

Manager claim	Verify One check (72 hours)	Result
44 occupied at $410	Rent roll, lot walk, bank deposits	Walk found 41 occupied; 3 derelict units counted as occupied. Claimed 44 x 410 x 12 = $216,480. Deposits $189,000. Gap $27,480, 12.7%.
Tenants pay on time	Deposits by month, 12 months	Realized $15,750/mo = $384.15 per occupied lot (15,750 / 41). Below the $410 claim. Late pattern on 3 lots.
Septic is fine	Septic pumper interview	Pumper: tank 3 pumped twice last year. Budget a camera inspection before close.
2 a.m. call goes to me, then the well guy	Well contractor invoice history	Two emergency callouts in 18 months at $900 each. Price it into the first-year reserve.

Decision box, filled

Transition. Keep the manager 60 days post-close to train the replacement, written scope, written pay. The manager retention plan is a first-30-days line item.

The interview did not produce facts. It produced leads. The documents produced the facts. That is the whole discipline.

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The Doctrine

The belief this interview shatters is that the manager is a source. A source gets mined for facts and dismissed. The manager is the operating system of the park. They hold the undocumented knowledge: which valve sticks, which tenant pays cash on the fifth, which vendor answers at midnight. Buyers who treat them as a source extract facts. Operators plan the transition around them. The one rule: every material claim gets verified against a document within 72 hours, and the retain, transition, or replace decision is written before closing, not after the first crisis. The rite of passage is the day the manager retention plan becomes a line item in your first 30 days. That is the day you stop buying a property and start buying an operation.

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